

No-nonsense Notebook

You're the professional on the move. You need a hassle-free platform to go about your daily business. Will it be Vista, Mac OS X or Linux? Read on

Nimish Chandiramani

While the world's waited for Vista, the alternatives—Linux and Mac OS X—have had the time to garner some attention; fans of those systems have lost no opportunity to tempt you to forsake Microsoft and join their ranks.

In light of these developments, it's about time we took a look beyond all the hype, the cheeky advertisements and the fanaticism, and found out which of these systems wins the productivity war. More professionals are going mobile these days, so we'll be looking at how they fare as laptop platforms. A lot of things will hold true for desktops as well, naturally. In the ring are Windows Vista—any new laptop you buy today will come with it; OS X Tiger on a MacBook Pro; and SUSE Linux Enterprise Desktop (SLED—a paid distribution, or distro), as well as Ubuntu, which is widely regarded as the best free Linux distro. You can also buy support for Ubuntu in India—we're looking at solutions where people get paid to solve your problems.

Our Methods And Madnesses

We spent a couple of weeks with each platform, and went about our daily business—surfing the Internet, e-mailing, creating and editing documents, tinkering with new applications, and generally getting our lives organised. And so it begins...

Into The Interfaces

Working in Vista isn't too different from working with XP, though it's better in many ways. There's a taskbar item for *everything*, so no more using [Alt] + [Tab] to hunt for dialog boxes that lost focus. Buttons are more indicative—the confirmation dialogs in Vista say "Perform Action" and "Don't Perform Action" (depending on the action, of course), so you don't need to read a lecture.

You no longer need to hold down [Ctrl] or [Shift] to select multiple files—you can enable checkboxes in Explorer's Folder Options, and do exactly what that implies: check the files you want to select, or use the checkbox at the top to select all files. [Alt] + [Tab] is bigger, and features application thumbnails. If you have a graphics card that can handle it, there are pretty effects too.

Mac OS X delivers a substantial culture shock to first-timers. Desktop icons are to the right of the screen, the control buttons have gone over to the left, and application menus have moved to the top of the screen rather than within the window itself. Then there's the Dock, a Quick Launch toolbar and taskbar rolled into one. Application icons jump when it is starting or if it has a message for you.

Still, after a couple of hours of poking and prodding, OS X's design becomes easy to work with. Some things continue to bother us, though—most notably the fact that selecting a file and hitting [Enter] *renames* it! To run the file, you have to use [Command] + [O] or [Command] + [Down Arrow].

OS X isn't the most keyboard-friendly platform either, so we found ourselves using the touchpad more often than we'd like. We're used to using [Alt] + [letter] combinations to get to menu items, but you can't do this with OS X: you have to access the menu bar using [Ctrl] + [F2] first ([Ctrl] + [Fn] + [F2] on a MacBook or MacBook Pro) and then use the arrow keys to navigate to the menu you want. While its *Finder* function has support for drag-and-drop, you can't use shortcuts like [Command] + [C] to copy files. These instances can be quite frustrating.

Both SUSE and Ubuntu are based on the GNOME Desktop Environment, but they've customised it differently. SUSE prefers the Windows-style look—taskbar at the bottom of the screen, a start menu with your favourite applications that

